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## The OpenSUSE Tumbleweed Rolling Distribution Goes Mainstream

Here is a record of my initial explorations and findings about the recently released OpenSUSE rolling distribution repository, Tumbleweed, as experienced on a netbook.

I almost bought an Android phone. I hesitated, wondering whether it would be upgradeable to 2.2 or 2.3? I am not in the habit of changing phones even once a year. So, I got myself a phone that is, well, 'just a phone'. Upon reflection, all I needed was the ability to receive calls and SMS messages and, rarely, make some calls. If I couldn't upgrade the software versions, its value as a playground for experimenting with mobile applications was very limited.

Desktop distribution versions can be equally frustrating. For several years, I have felt that while version upgrades may be very useful for proprietary distributions, they are counter-productive for open source options.

For over a year, I have had Arch Linux on a couple of systems, using the most recent versions of various applications with no issues and no upgrade hassles. Sadly, the rumours of Ubuntu moving to a rolling distribution turned out to be incorrect (see <http://ubuntulook.com/2010/11/26/ubuntu-rolling-release-rumours-wrong/>).

Rolling distributions are not unknown to mainstream distributions. OpenSUSE's factory repository or Fedora's rawhide repositories are rolling distributions. The problem with them is that they are unstable. There have been some implicit assumptions about distributions, like:

- Anyone wanting a rolling distribution wants to be on the bleeding edge.
- A 6-month release cycle is a reasonable compromise between the need to be current, and the goal of stability.

The release dates are arbitrary. The versions of packages that make it to a particular distribution are arbitrary decisions. For instance, it is entirely possible that not all packages within a distribution are stable; or that a stable version of a package is available but is not included in the recent/supported

distribution; or that synchronising release cycles with upstream package release cycles is not a workable option, or any other reason.

Ubuntu encourages the use of PPAs to be selectively 'rolling', but the mindset remains that of frozen 'stable' distributions. Hence, it was a pleasant surprise to read that OpenSUSE was releasing Tumbleweed along with the OpenSUSE 11.4 versions. The Tumbleweed repository would be a rolling release.

### Moving to Tumbleweed

So, what do you need to do to try it? The machine I was going to install Tumbleweed on was a Lenovo S10-3 netbook. I was going to use the Plasma Netbook Workspace, which is what I used with Arch Linux and Fedora on this system. You obviously do not need to stick to a netbook or the KDE desktop. However, you do need to start with an OpenSUSE 11.4 distribution. There was one distributed with LFY's April 2011 issue.

Various possibilities are available at <http://download.opensuse.org/distribution/11.4/iso/> but I used the KDE LiveCD. After installing the 11.4 distribution, you need to follow the steps shown at <http://en.opensuse.org/Portal:Tumbleweed>. Using 'zypper' instead of 'yum' or 'pacman' isn't hard. The key process is:

```
$ sudo zypper dup --from Tumbleweed
```

And pretty soon, a number of new packages like the 2.6.38 Linux kernel will replace the versions from the 11.4 repositories with those available in the Tumbleweed repository. You may enable additional official repositories, as described at [http://en.opensuse.org/Package\\_repositories](http://en.opensuse.org/Package_repositories). You can also add the Packman repository for the additional codecs and applications. I needed it for Miro.